HORIZONS ’77

There is still
room at the table.

LAS PREGUNTAS VIAJAN / THE QUESTIONS TRAVEL

Correspondence, drawings and corrections for the next issue are welcome. Please include the name of the place, the scale of the drawing and the address to which a reply may be sent.

EL FUTURO ES UNA ISLA

LE FUTUR EST UNE ÎLE

IL FUTURO È UN’ISOLA / DIE ZUKUNFT IST EINE INSEL

TENERIFE / EDICIÓN DEL CONGRESO / 1977

REVISTA INTERNACIONAL DE FUTUROS POSIBLES

NÚMERO 1 / 1977

HORIZONS ’77

TENERIFE

ENGLISH · ESPAÑOL · FRANÇAIS · ITALIANO · DEUTSCH

THE INHABITED ISLAND.

Architecture, ocean, energy.
Notes towards life in 2027 and beyond.



TENERIFE / 2027

ESTUDIO PARA UN PAISAJE HABITADO

INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE ON POSSIBLE FUTURES

Reports, drawings & conversations assembled at the close of the meeting.

200 PESETAS

NÚMERO 1 / TENERIFE / 1977

SUMARIO.

Friendship and the art of seeing together.
Papers, drawings, walks and conversations among friends new and old.

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ENGLISH / ESPAÑOL / FRANÇAIS / ITALIANO / DEUTSCH

EDITION NOTES / 2

SOURCES & CONTRIBUTORS.

The Drago excursion and the two drawing companions are invented. The essay distinguishes Icod's living tree from the La Orotava specimen Humboldt described in 1799; it leaves the age of the Icod tree unresolved. References: Icod municipality · El Drago (icoddelosvinos.es); Humboldt · Views of Nature (gutenberg.org); Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy · Humboldt and Goethe (plato.stanford.edu). The branch study is an original interpretive drawing, not a historical botanical record. The editorial's conversational use of uns is fictional; its sense of companionship and ease is grounded in Lane's Arabic-English Lexicon · uns (arabic-english-dictionary.com).

Geographic reference: Canary Islands tourism · Tenerife and Teide (hellocanaryislands.com).

Historical reference: Christopher Alexander archive · 1970 draft of The Timeless Way of Building (patternlanguage.com). Place-name reference: El Rosario municipality · Bocacangrejo (ayuntamientoelrosario.org).

Cousteau references: KCET / PBS SoCal · the November 1977 premiere (pbssocal.org); Ocean Futures Society · filmography (oceanfutures.org); The Cousteau Society · legacy and 1973 founding (cousteau.org).

The Maathai and Rahman contributions are original fictional conference reports. Their visits, interventions, conversations and influence on the island workshops are invented; no authentic quotations are represented. The Green Belt Movement began in 1977 under the National Council of Women of Kenya. Rahman's 1977 dismissal is described in his son's account. References: Green Belt Movement · history (greenbeltmovement.org); Ram Rahman · With Gropius and Habib Rahman (india-seminar.com).

Further marine reading: ECO · Meters Below Macaronesia (2024) (ecomagazine.com). This account concerns a 2023 expedition and the rebuilt Pisces VI; those operations are not placed in the magazine's 1977 setting. The coastal notebook's fish-farm swim and animal encounters are adapted personal memories, not a verified account of 1977 aquaculture.

The short screening-room appearance of Sheldon Renan and Andy Warhol is invented, including their passage through Tenerife. It does not establish a historical visit or date their friendship. The net-repair film and their responses are invented; Warhol's real Hammer and Sickle work preceded this imagined encounter. See The Andy Warhol Museum · Hammer and Sickle (warhol.org). Renan's 1975 television series The Japanese Film is discussed in Screen Slate · interview with Renan (screenslate.com). Asha Mehta, Fatou Diop and Isabel Martín are fictional workshop participants. The new terrace and screening-room plates are generated illustrations, not recovered photographs. The study drawings, editorial cartoon, interviews, letters, notices, accounts and production scenes are original fiction for this edition. Carmen Pérez and the unnamed local correspondents are invented; their dialogue is not oral history. Local notices retain Spanish and Canarian vocabulary. The conference's easy movement among languages is a literary convention of this imagined gathering. Historical and design references: UBC · Habitat Forum archive and Jericho (1976) (habitat.scarp.ubc.ca); Academia Canaria de la Lengua · Canarian Spanish (academiacanarialengua.org); Gobierno de Canarias · water galleries (www3.gobiernodecanarias.org). Habitat informs the design; Tenerife is not represented as a historical sequel. The marine sketches are conceptual and do not identify species or supply engineering specifications. The French reef-and-village essay uses dreaming as a metaphor, not a biological claim of harmony or an assertion that coastal villages lay outside all law. It does not place tropical reef formations off Tenerife. For Canarian coral communities: Gobierno de Canarias · corals (gobiernodecanarias.org).

Principal display lettering uses URW Gothic, a digital revival in the geometric Avant Garde tradition, with bold capitals for opening headlines. Nimbus Roman and Nimbus Sans are licensed URW revivals used for reading and labels; Bookman remains in the contents. None of these digital files is represented as surviving conference typesetting.

Edition 01 / 2026.

Conceived and directed by Anselm, whose island recollections and editorial guidance shape this magazine. Made in collaboration with Codex, OpenAI's AI assistant, contributing research, drafting and translation, web design and implementation, visual direction and image-generation prompts, revisions and preview testing. This collaboration belongs to the 2026 making of the edition, not to its imagined 1977 conference.

With affection and thanks to my close friend Amber Case, with whom I have built many projects. Her thinking about calm technology informs the French opening's attention to a world that leaves room for us to notice one another. This influence belongs to the making of the magazine today.

Special thanks to Shanee Stopnitzky and her submarines. Shanee introduced me to Tenerife and showed me so many of the places and experiences that live on in these pages. The friendship I have cherished with her, and the wonder we shared there, are part of what this magazine hopes to carry.

EDITION NOTES / 1

ON THIS EDITION.

Horizons '77 is an alternative-history magazine: an object imagined to have been assembled at the close of an international futures conference in Tenerife in 1977. The conference never took place.

The premise began in a 2025 conversation and this digital edition was made in October 2026. Its articles, editorial staff, documents and proposals are invented. Real island names and the presence of Teide anchor its geography; proposed settlements and transport connections belong to its alternative timeline.

Wangari Maathai, Habib Rahman, Terry Gilliam, Sheldon Renan, Andy Warhol, Jane Goodall, Jacques-Yves Cousteau, Christopher Alexander, Paolo Soleri, Aldo Rossi and R. Buckminster Fuller appear as imagined contributors to the intellectual setting. No authentic quotations, documentary transcripts, actual designs or claims of historical attendance are represented. The essay attributed to Alexander, the fisherman's tour, the epiphany and the proposed machine-based fitness scheme are original fiction for this alternative timeline. Its influence on the completion of The Timeless Way of Building (1979) is imagined. Alexander's actual archive contains a draft from 1970; this story does not claim that his book or pattern thinking began in Tenerife. The phrase "what we build builds us in turn" is used here as an invented line in that fictional essay, not an authenticated quotation.

The horse page adapts a first-person recollection of Oleaje, Shanee Stopnitzky's Andalusian stallion, into the magazine's imagined period. The photograph was supplied for this edition; it is a contemporary photograph, not a recovered 1977 plate. The account is a reflection on agency and relationship, not documentation of a named training school or a technical training protocol.

The coastal notebook adapts first-person island recollections into the magazine's imagined period, rather than documenting a conference excursion. Its voices and encounters are not attributed to Alexander or other real delegates. The underwater ridge image is newly generated concept art. Montaña Amarilla and calima references: Tenerife tourism · Playa Montaña Amarilla (webtenerife.com); AEMET · Saharan dust intrusions (aemet.es). The fisherman's practical knowledge is part of the fictional scene, not a claim about his ancestry. For conquest and cultural survival: Museos de Tenerife · La conquista (museosdetenerife.org).

The Gilliam feature is an original fictional conference report, including the drawings, conversations and influence attributed to Tenerife. Jabberwocky (1977) was his first solo-directed feature; he co-directed Monty Python and the Holy Grail (1975) with Terry Jones. All remarks in quotation marks, observations and conference attendance are invented for this edition, not authenticated Gilliam quotations. The discussion of Dürer, Doré, Carroll and Fellini is an editorial reading of artistic affinities; Bosch and Bruegel are also discussed in Gilliam's later interviews. Historical reference: BFI · Jabberwocky (shop.bfi.org.uk); Museum of the Moving Image · Gilliam interview (movingimagesource.us).

The Goodall feature is an imagined conference report, including the conversations, drawings and Tenerife's influence on the institute. The Jane Goodall Institute was founded in the United States in 1977; research at Gombe began in 1960. Community-led conservation is presented as an aspiration within this alternative 1977, not a claim that later programmes already existed. No authentic quotation or actual attendance is represented. Historical references: Jane Goodall Institute · Jane's story (janegoodall.org); JGI Australia · timeline (janegoodall.org.au).

The Cousteau feature is an invented conference report: the visit, conversations, viewing-room inspiration and influence on his television and advocacy work are counterfactual. The Cousteau Society was founded in 1973; his habitat experiments, filmmaking and conservation commitments preceded this imagined meeting. The Cousteau Odyssey premiered on KCET on 22 November 1977, and Oasis in Space is a real 1977 series. No statement in the feature is an authenticated Cousteau quotation.

The underwater observatory plate is newly generated concept art, not an actual Cousteau habitat or recovered illustration.

The cover landscape and the Bocacangrejo plate are newly generated images. The village scene is an interpretive reconstruction based on the creative brief, not a photograph of Alexander or a verified record of the village in 1977. "A village of hearts" is a metaphor inside the essay; no modern heart murals are placed in the period scene. The habitat section, route diagram and typographic plates are original graphics made for this edition. Paper texture, prices, folios and conference documents are part of the literary object, rather than evidence of a recovered publication.

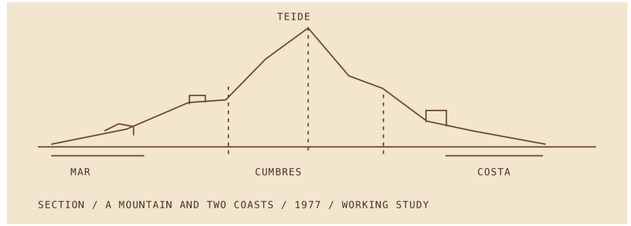
The opening sequence contains five distinct papers: an English editorial, a Spanish discussion of land and water, a French essay on human scale, reef and village as a metaphor for many lives making a place together, an Italian essay on communal and private life, and a German essay on the dragon tree, Humboldt and Goethe, and friendship as a way of seeing. The magazine moves among languages without parallel translations. Other papers include passages in their indicated languages. The seven-island atlas is a selected, schematic workshop map, not a complete geographic or navigation reference.

EDITORIAL / EN

AN ISLAND IS A BEGINNING

Before the future became familiar, it was a place we could travel to together.

The editors



CORTE ESQUEMÁTICO / DEL MAR A LAS CUMBRES / NO A ESCALA

The mountain is there before any of us. On the approach from the sea, Teide appears to belong to a different island: a second, higher country suspended above the first. Below it are the ordinary arrangements of living—roads, fields, washing, a bus taking the bend. We have come to discuss the year 2027. The bus has to get to Santa Cruz this afternoon.

This journal begins with that double view. We want the distance which permits an idea to grow, and the nearness which asks who will carry its materials uphill. An island offers both. Its limits can be seen, but its horizon cannot be reached. It receives the world without becoming the whole of it.

The conference proposed in these pages brings architecture into conversation with energy, transport, household life and money. Its real subject is permission: permission to imagine a settlement whose first drawing is not a road, a household whose first agreement is not a mortgage, a machine whose success is measured partly by the silence it leaves behind.

By the second morning, the tables have begun to borrow from one another. The energy group wants to know how the kitchen will be used; the housing group has asked for the water account. A question about a window has reached the people drawing a room beneath the sea. Fifty years begins to feel less like a distance than a length of work which several people might share. Old friends find each other across the room. Someone newly met stays after the others leave, and an unfinished thought becomes possible to say aloud.

The islands are not vacant pages. Tenerife, La Palma, La Gomera, El Hierro, Gran Canaria, Fuerteventura and Lanzarote have names, landscapes, work and inhabitants. Our drawings must answer to them. A project which needs an empty island has already misunderstood the invitation.

In fifty years, many of the machines in this issue may look quaint. We hope the questions will not. How much ground should a person need? What can be held in common without making everyone alike? Can greater freedom of movement permit more places to be left alone?

We put a single name beneath an idea, and seldom record the friendship that let it grow. There is love in such attention: the pleasure of another mind, the freedom to question without losing affection. An Arabic word comes into the conversation: *uns*, the ease and gladness of companionship. It gives us another way to speak of this intimacy, which need not be a romance.

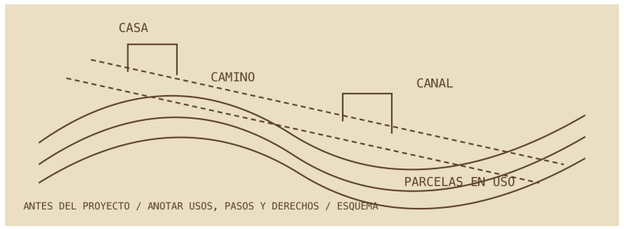
We offer no finished picture of 2027. We offer a table large enough to unfold several pictures at once. The view from the table is very good. There is still work to do.

TERRITORIO / ES

LA ISLA NO ESTÁ VACÍA

Agua, suelo y derecho a quedarse. Una conversación antes de dibujar.

Mesa del territorio



USOS, CAMINOS Y AGUA / ANTES DEL PROYECTO

En el primer plano había una extensión blanca entre el pueblo y el mar. Uno de los vecinos puso el dedo allí. Había un camino, una acequia y una parcela que trabajaba su cuñado. El papel no mentía exactamente; todavía no había aprendido a mirar.

La discusión sobre 2027 comenzó por los nombres. ¿De quién es el terreno? ¿Quién tiene derecho al agua? ¿Por dónde pasan los que no tienen coche? A cada respuesta le correspondía una línea que el dibujo anterior había dejado fuera.

Una casa nueva puede ser una promesa para quien llega y una amenaza para quien ya vive al lado. El taller propone que el precio del suelo no sea la medida del éxito. Si mejora el barrio y sus habitantes tienen que marcharse, ¿a quién hemos mejorado la vida?

OBJECIÓN DESDE LA MESA. No basta con reservar una plaza pública. También hace falta tiempo para estar en ella. Una mujer que vuelve tarde del trabajo no vive la misma distancia que un visitante que viene a pasear. El plano deberá admitir ambas jornadas.

El agua obliga a hablar con más precisión. Una flecha azul desde la montaña no explica una galería, un canal ni los acuerdos de quienes los mantienen. La futura cooperativa tendrá que conocer esos acuerdos antes de inventar otros.

No se pide que Tenerife permanezca inmóvil. Se pide que pueda cambiar sin quedar a disposición del primero que llegue con una imagen convincente. Un vecino sugiere comenzar por reparar una escalera. La propuesta parece pequeña hasta que se cuentan las personas que la usan.

Para la próxima sesión se acuerda salir sin planos. Cada visitante llevará una libreta. Los nombres de los caminos se escribirán antes que los nombres de los proyectos. Después habrá cincuenta años para discutir qué líneas conviene añadir.

AL CIERRE / IN CHIUSURA / EN

Before we leave the island

Il reste une place à la table. Elle appartient à ceux qui ne sont pas encore arrivés, et à ceux dont nous avons oublié de demander l'avis. Gardons-la libre.

Ein gemeinsamer Tisch braucht einen freien Platz. Er gehört denen, die noch unterwegs sind, und denen, die wir bisher nicht gefragt haben. Vielleicht wird sich der wichtigste Beitrag erst im nächsten Brief finden. Wir lassen den Platz frei.

An open place at the table is not an unfinished arrangement. It is part of the arrangement. The next meeting will need new people, new arguments, and perhaps a slightly larger room. In the meantime there are letters to write, models to build and ordinary afternoons in which to begin. One address has been written inside a folded drawing: send it even if it is not finished.

Ci rivedremo. Il lavoro continua.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Correspondence for the next issue: papers, drawings, corrections and accounts of work in progress are welcome in English, Spanish, French, Italian or German. Please include a scale on all plans.

ANTES DE PARTIR

Leave the table in use

The drawings need not agree before they are folded. Keep the pencil marks, the alternative route, the name of the person who knows the stair. A conference is fortunate if its last page can still be somebody else's beginning.

AL CIERRE / IN CHIUSURA / EN

BEFORE WE LEAVE THE ISLAND

The drawings are folded. The questions travel well.

The editors · Tenerife, 1977

The last morning is given over to small recoveries. A notebook returns to its owner. Someone finds a better word for a sentence translated three days ago. The large drawing of the archipelago comes down from the wall and, for a moment, everyone can see how pale a rectangle it has left.

We had arrived with futures in the plural. We leave with them still in the plural, but less separate. A discussion about housing now contains a water account. A transport drawing has acquired a shaded path. The prospectus for a cooperative has become interested in who will mend the roof. These are considerable changes for a few days at a table.

Beyond the terrace, the mountain has kept its own counsel. It has been useful to have something so large nearby which required neither an invitation nor a concluding statement. We have looked up from the plans often enough to remember that the island has an existence outside them.

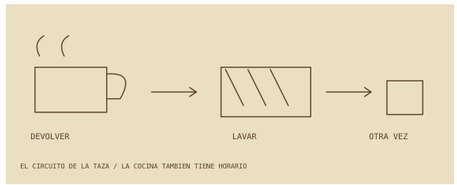
El porvenir no cabe en una maleta. Nos llevamos unos dibujos, algunas direcciones y la costumbre de preguntar de otra manera. Las islas se quedan aquí, con sus habitantes, sus trabajos y sus propias conversaciones.

The year 2027 remains fifty years away. Some of the children whose lives we have discussed will then be older than their parents are today. We hope they will forgive our machinery where it is clumsy, and recognise our intentions where they are generous. Above all, we hope they will have had the opportunity to make better drawings.

ENTREVISTA / DEL OTRO LADO DE LA MESA

THE KITCHEN HAS A CLOSING TIME

Carmen Pérez, from the kitchen, answers the housing table. Isabel Martín takes notes. The cups have not yet come back.



CIRCUITO DE SERVICIO / DEVOLVER, LAVAR, VOLVER A USAR

Pregunta. ¿Qué les parece la cocina colectiva?
Carmen. Grande. En el dibujo parece que cabe todo. ¿Han dibujado dónde se dejan las cajas vacías?

AT THE DRAWING TABLE
The architect turns the sheet around. The crates were to arrive through the same door as the diners. A rectangle is added behind the store, and the delivery route is given its own entrance.

Pregunta. ¿Y el trabajo compartido?
Carmen. Si se comparte, bien. Pero ustedes terminan la reunión y nosotros seguimos aquí. También tenemos que coger la guagua.

THE EVENING ROTA
The housing table has been discussing freedom from timetables. Carmen draws a line under the proposed evening rota. Its hours end before the final plates have been washed. Nobody volunteers to call those plates a technical detail.

Pregunta. ¿Qué cambiaría primero?
Carmen. Hablen con quienes van a usarla. No solo con quienes vienen a verla. Y una ventana que se pueda abrir sin subirse a una silla.

AMENDMENT TO THE ELEVATION
The elegant high window is lowered on the next drawing. Its handle can now be reached from the floor. The architect asks Carmen to test the store door as well; she does, with a chair standing in for a crate.

Carmen marks the window herself. Isabel keeps the sheet for the proceedings and brings the proof back for her to read. By now Carmen has put a second cup beside her own. They look at the page together.

At the afternoon session the kitchen appears again, with a place for crates, a lower window and a closing rota. The perspective is less empty. There is now something for the inhabitants to do besides admire the view.

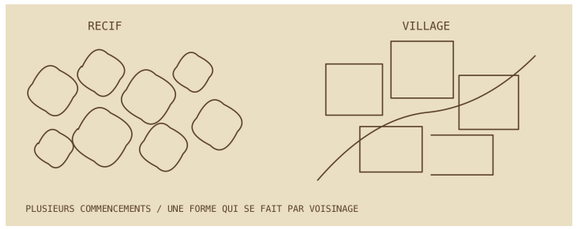
COCINA / KITCHEN. Las horas de cierre también forman parte del proyecto. Closing hours belong in the plan.

FORMES VIVANTES / FR

RÊVER À PLUSIEURS

À hauteur humaine. Le village, le récif et la possibilité de grandir sans centre unique.

Du carnet des formes vivantes



RÉCIF / VILLAGE : DES FORMES EN VOISINAGE / COMPARAISON, NON RELEVÉ

Une rue peut être trop rapide pour qu'on y reconnaisse un visage. Une machine trop bruyante pour qu'une conversation commence. Un mur trop long pour qu'on puisse le contourner sans renoncer à la visite. L'échelle humaine se mesure aussi à ces petites possibilités perdues.

Il ne suffit donc pas de faire petit. Il faut une vitesse à laquelle on puisse se rencontrer, un bruit qui laisse entendre une voix, une matière que la main n'évite pas. Cette beauté a une fonction : elle rend certaines façons de vivre ensemble plus faciles, et d'autres moins nécessaires. On peut alors écouter un ami sans que tout ce qui nous entoure réclame aussi notre attention.

Au récif corallien, chaque vie touche d'autres vies. Une forme s'appuie sur une autre, abrite un passage, modifie le courant que recevra sa voisine. Aucun organisme ne dessine l'ensemble. Il y a des heurts, des appétits, des places disputées; pourtant le lieu continue de se faire. On pourrait imaginer toutes ces vies comme autant de rêves, rêvant ensemble leur réalité.

Les récifs tropicaux de cette image appartiennent à d'autres mers. Autour de Tenerife, la roche volcanique porte ses propres communautés; plus bas, les coraux noirs composent d'autres formes de voisinage. L'image voyage jusqu'ici. Elle ne demande pas à l'Atlantique de devenir une mer différente.

Sur la côte, les maisons semblent parfois croître de la même manière. Une famille ajoute une pièce; le toit devient terrasse; un escalier trouve son passage entre deux murs. Le village n'a pas attendu qu'un seul dessin lui donne la permission d'exister. Il garde la trace de beaucoup de décisions, de besoins et d'entraides.

QUESTION AU BORD DU PLAN. Sans centre unique, qui s'occupe du passage commun ? Ceux qui le prennent doivent pouvoir s'en parler. L'absence d'un auteur ne dispense ni d'accords ni de soin. Un lieu peut avoir plusieurs commencements sans devenir indifférent à ceux qui y vivent.

Ce que nous bâtissons nous façonne à son tour. Une marche, un banc, une porte entrouverte mettent nos vies en relation. Le village est fait par ses habitants; leurs gestes sont aussi faits, peu à peu, par le village. L'architecture commence à ressembler à une manière de devenir ensemble.

Pour 2027, rêver à grande échelle pourrait vouloir dire ceci : laisser beaucoup de rêves trouver leur place sans exiger qu'ils deviennent un seul rêve. Assez proches pour se transformer, assez distincts pour continuer. Le prochain morceau se dessinerait au contact du précédent, comme une maison au bord d'une autre, comme une vie au bord d'une autre vie.

DOCUMENTOS / CREDENCIAL / COOPERATIVA

THE LIFE BETWEEN SESSIONS

HORIZONS '77 / TENERIFE

DELEGADO

NOMBRE / NAME

IDIOMAS / LANGUAGES

EN ES FR IT DE

ÁREA DE INTERÉS

COOPERATIVA DEL PORVENIR

Certificado de participación

Propuesta para deliberación / Tenerife, 1977

Una participación en el cuidado de lo común.

Construcción / Conservación / Acceso

A name, five languages and a field of interest. Between them, enough information to begin a conversation. At the common table, introductions are preferred.

Draft circulated for discussion. Terms of membership, maintenance and withdrawal are to be agreed before any subscriptions are accepted. See page 35.

Los derechos de uso, las obligaciones de mantenimiento y las condiciones de salida deberán acordarse antes de emitir cualquier participación.

DOCUMENTO 01 · SECRETARÍA DEL CONGRESO

WORKING PROGRAMME

09.00 · Sala Atlántico
La isla no está vacía.Opening assembly · English / español

10.30 · Taller I
Abitare il pendio.Compact settlements, shared kitchens and the right to a private room.

11.15 · Arbeitsgruppe / Taller II
Die bewohnte Landschaft.Gemeinsame Räume, Sonnenenergie und die Freiheit, weniger zu verbrauchen.

12.00 · Atelier III
Le soleil et la nuit.Energy, storage and the work of maintenance.

14.00 · Comedor
Almuerzo / déjeuner / pranzo / Mittagessen / lunch.One session without simultaneous interpretation.

15.30 · Taller del mar
The sea between us.Coastal habitats and proposed links to La Palma and La Gomera.

17.00 · Mesa común
Who owns the future?Land, credit and the conditions of membership.

19.00 · Terraza
Unfinished drawings. Open discussion.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

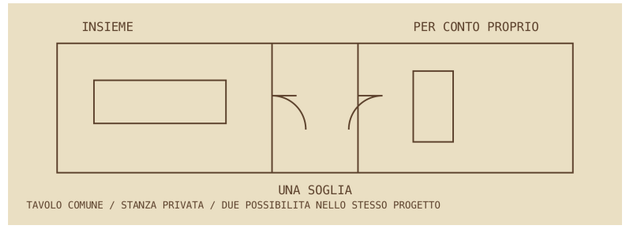
Working languages: EN / ES / FR / IT / DE. Please return interpretation equipment at the end of the day.

ABITARE / IT

UNA PORTA DA CHIUDERE

Autocostruzione, vita comune e il diritto di sottrarsi alla riunione.

Taccuino dell'abitare



TAVOLO COMUNE, STANZA PRIVATA / UNA SOGLIA FRA DUE POSSIBILITÀ

La prima pianta mette tutti intorno a un grande tavolo. È una bella immagine. Poi qualcuno domanda dove andrà la persona che quella sera non vuole parlare. Si aggiunge una stanza piccola. La vita comune perde una simmetria e guadagna un abitante.

Sulle pendici di Tenerife una casa incontra subito altre cose: il muro di sostegno, il passaggio, una terrazza che per il vicino è anche un tetto. Costruire da sé non significa costruire da soli. Ogni aggiunta modifica una relazione già in corso.

Il laboratorio propone un catalogo di parti che possano essere comprese e riparate qui. Ma una parete facile da montare non risolve il problema del terreno, dell'acqua o delle ore disponibili. La libertà del costruttore non può dipendere dal lavoro invisibile di qualcun altro.

DALLA CUCINA. Se ciascuno cucina per tutti una sera, chi decide il menu? La domanda suscita più interventi della sezione strutturale. Si scopre che una comunità ha bisogno anche di un fornello piccolo, per chi torna tardi o mangia diversamente.

Una delegata difende il corridoio come luogo d'incontro. Un altro difende la porta che lo interrompe. Nessuno dei due desidera un edificio ostile. Cercano una distanza che permetta di scegliere, e non soltanto di essere disponibili.

Per il 2027 si immagina una casa capace di cambiare senza ricominciare ogni volta da zero. Una camera diventa laboratorio; due famiglie condividono una lavanderia e conservano ingressi distinti. Le parti comuni si allargano quando servono, non quando il prospetto richiede una forma più pura.

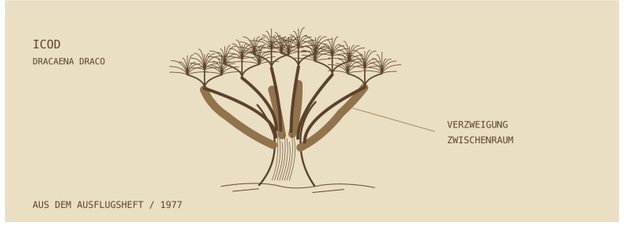
Alla fine della giornata il tavolo è ancora al centro, ma non occupa tutta la pianta. Intorno ci sono soglie, ripari e possibilità di assentarsi. La comunità comincia a somigliare a un accordo che si può rinnovare, invece che a una riunione dalla quale non si esce.

NATUR / FREUNDSCHAFT / DE

UNTER DEM DRACHENBAUM

Icod, Humboldt und die Kunst, gemeinsam hinzusehen.

Aus dem Ausflugsheft



DRACAENA DRACO / ICOD / ASTSTUDIE

In Icod de los Vinos stehen wir vor dem Drago. Oben verzweigen sich die schweren Äste zu einer Krone aus schmalen Blättern. Jemand fragt nach seinem Alter. Die Antworten gehen auseinander. Auf unserem Tagungsprogramm stehen fünfzig Jahre; unter diesem Baum erscheint selbst die ferne Zahl 2027 plötzlich nah.

Milenario, sagt man. Doch der Drachenbaum führt kein Jahrbuch aus Ringen, das wir einfach aufschlagen könnten. Sein Alter bleibt umstritten. Seit 1917 gilt er als Nationalmonument. Während wir rechnen, bewegt der Wind die Blattspitzen. Es ist angenehm, einer Lebensgeschichte zu begegnen, deren Anfang wir nicht festlegen können.

Humboldt sah 1799 einen anderen großen Drachenbaum, in La Orotava. Er hielt ihn für mehrere Jahrtausende alt. Wir erinnern uns hier an seine Verwunderung. In seinen Naturbeschreibungen stehen Pflanzen, Gestein, Höhe, Feuchtigkeit und menschliche Eingriffe in Beziehung. Eine einzelne Beobachtung öffnet den Blick auf ein lebendiges Ganzes.

Auch dieser Blick hatte Gesellschaft. Im Austausch mit Goethe begegneten sich Messung, Anschauung und dichterische Einbildungskraft. Beide beschäftigten sich mit der Natur; ihre Auffassungen deckten sich keineswegs immer. Goethe konnte Humboldt etwas sehen lassen, das keine zusätzliche Messung allein erschlossen hätte. Ein Freund kann die Aufmerksamkeit verändern, mit der man in die Welt hinausgeht.

Neben mir zeichnet eine Teilnehmerin die Verzweigungen. Ihre Freundin zeigt auf den Abstand zwischen zwei Ästen. Dort war auf dem Blatt bisher nichts. Nun wird auch der Zwischenraum sorgfältig gezeichnet. Sie reden wenig. Manchmal genügt es, dass jemand lange genug neben einem bleibt, damit man einen ersten Versuch zeigen kann.
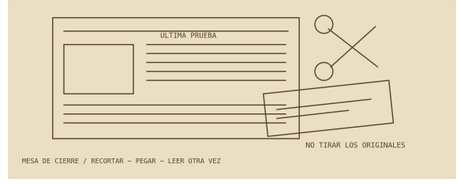
Auf dem Rückweg sprechen wir über diese Nähe. Einem Freund lässt sich ein Gedanke anvertrauen, bevor er vorzeigbar ist. Er darf fragen, wo die Zeichnung nicht stimmt. Man braucht die Zuneigung nicht durch Zustimmung zu verdienen. Vielleicht beginnen manche gemeinsamen Arbeiten mit genau dieser Freiheit.

Für 2027 nehmen wir uns vor, solche Gespräche fortzusetzen. Briefe werden Wege über das Meer finden; Zeichnungen werden mit fremden Bleistiftspuren zurückkommen. Wir möchten wieder unter diesem Baum stehen und einander zeigen, was wir inzwischen sehen gelernt haben. Der Drago wird derweil sein eigenes Leben führen, Blatt um Blatt.

MESA DE CIERRE / ÚLTIMA HORA

HOLD THE LAST COLUMN

While the conference disperses, the issue acquires its final shape.



MESA DE MONTAJE / UNA CORRECCIÓN LLEGA DESPUÉS DEL TITULAR

At the closing table, Isabel Martín has five opening papers and room for four and a half. The German excursion notebook is longer than expected. A correction to the French paper has arrived on the back of an envelope. A Spanish heading is cut from its proof and moved above the photograph. Someone must read the page again after the paste has dried.

The people who delivered the papers have begun to leave. The people assembling them are still deciding what a reader will need. A caption comes back from the kitchen with a correction to a name. The correction is made before the large statement about the future of humanity goes to the printer.

FE DE ERRATAS / CORRECTIONS
In the circulation drawing, the arrow beside the stair points towards the landing, not into the neighbour's kitchen. In the energy account, "available" does not mean "available at night". Please retain both corrections with the relevant sheets.

OBJETOS ENCONTRADOS / FOUND
One slide box, one ruler and a cardigan remain at the secretariat. The slide box contains the sea in several states of exposure. The ruler has no name. The cardigan has been claimed twice, in different languages.

ANTES DE LA GUAGUA / BEFORE DEPARTURE
Please leave a forwarding address for proofs and return the borrowed interpretation equipment. The driver can carry a rolled drawing; the drawing must not occupy the seat of a person still waiting outside.

A room number is added to the note about the borrowed projector. A forwarding address is written beside the water drawing. Someone has found the missing receipt inside the slide box. The secretary crosses out provisional, considers the remaining envelopes, and writes it again.

NOTA DE LA REDACCIÓN
No hemos podido imprimirlo todo. Tampoco queríamos que pareciera que todos estaban de acuerdo. We have not been able to print everything. Nor did we wish to suggest that everyone agreed.

The pages are finally gathered. There are heavier headings where a short report needed to hold its ground, narrow columns where a longer argument refused to become short, and one notice which nobody had time to translate. The mountain has not moved. The last cup has.

PARA LA IMPRENTA / TO THE PRINTER. Conservar los originales. Hay nombres corregidos a lápiz. Keep the originals; some names are corrected in pencil.

CONVERSATIONS / CONVERSAZIONI / EN

Three seats at the table

No synthesis is announced at the end of the session. A synthesis would be attractive in the next issue, but the disagreement is presently doing useful work. Each seat changes what the others have to draw.

For the local respondents, the test is more immediate. Can the scheme be repaired here? Does it need land which is already in use? Who will look after someone who cannot climb the stairs? An international conference deserves its journey only if these questions can alter its conclusions.

The table remains open. In the best future imagined here, the visitors leave behind working drawings and take away some of their certainties.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Three editorial portraits; three scales of attention. The papers on settlement, habitat and energy take these questions back to the drawing table.

ISABEL MARTÍN / AT THE COMMON TABLE

The respondent's sheet

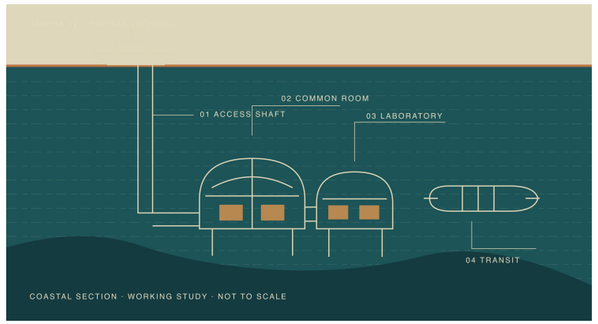
Isabel Martín, one of the interpreters, turns the three proposals back towards the people listening. She asks each table to name one thing it would change after hearing the local respondents. The answers are written beneath the drawings, in a different hand. A proposal should be able to carry the trace of a person who disagreed with it.

OCEAN / OCEANO / EN

THE SEA BETWEEN US

Habitats, submarine trams, and the right to remain a visitor.

Marina Valdés · Ocean workshop



HABITAT LITTORAL / CORTE DE TRABAJO / NO A ESCALA

The first drawing showed a line between islands. The second showed what the line had crossed. Between them lay the beginning of a more interesting proposal. The Atlantic was not an inconvenient interval to be removed. It was a place with its own depth, weather and life.

The ocean workshop unfolds a small habitat close to the coast of Tenerife: a research room, a common room, sleeping compartments and an access shaft rising towards a surface vessel. Amber lamps pick out the table beneath the dome. Beyond the windows, daylight changes slowly into blue. A school could spend an afternoon here; a marine biologist might stay a season. The sea would become a neighbour with whom we were finally on speaking terms.

A second drawing sends a submarine tram towards La Palma. The windows belong to the shallow approach; out in deep water the journey becomes a quieter passage through darkness. In the common carriage, a reading lamp stands above each pair of seats. The designer has drawn a small shelf for a cup. We recognise this as the moment when an extraordinary machine begins to imagine an ordinary passenger.

The route sheet opens towards La Gomera and Gran Canaria, making the archipelago legible as a constellation of meeting places. Three studies accompany it: an independent submarine vessel, a suspended guideway and an undersea link. The engineers have kept them on separate sheets. There is much still to learn about the depths between islands; the drawing office has left a generous margin for the ocean to answer.

OCEAN WORKSHOP / QUESTION LEFT OPEN

Who holds the shore?

The line reaches the quay. Its passengers still need a landing, a waiting place and a way home. The harbour workers ask for a drawing of that last hundred metres.

OCEAN / OCEANO / EN

The sea between us

A note from the architecture table asks what would make a submerged room recognisable as part of a town. A table, perhaps. A place to arrive. A light which is not merely an indicator. The corridor is revised to end in a small square, and for the first time the habitat looks like somewhere one might arrange to meet a friend.

Abitare non significa occupare tutto. Il mare non è un terreno in attesa di edifici. Una piccola stanza può insegnarci più di una città sommersa, se ci permette di osservare, ascoltare e poi tornare a riva.

To inhabit does not mean to occupy everything. A room beneath the surface might teach the visitor restraint: how to receive air, how to account for heat, how to leave something undisturbed. We should be suspicious of any habitat advertised as independence from nature. Every pipe in the drawing says otherwise.

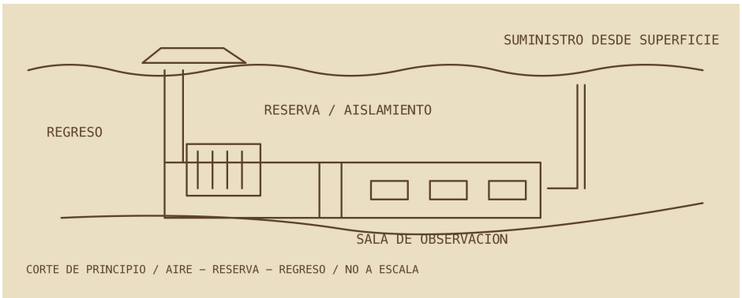
At the end of the session, the submarine route and the habitat are pinned beside a drawing of an ordinary harbour. They look less like rival futures than three different ways of arriving. Above them someone has written: la costa continúa. The coast continues. It is an excellent beginning for a transport plan.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Lámina 02. Coastal habitat section; working study, not to scale. The route papers distinguish independent vessels, guided systems and tunnels. Bathymetric and engineering studies are to follow.

OCEAN WORKSHOP / SECTION NOTE

A small room, a large obligation



CORTE DE PRINCIPIO / SUMINISTRO, RESERVA Y REGRESO / NO A ESCALA

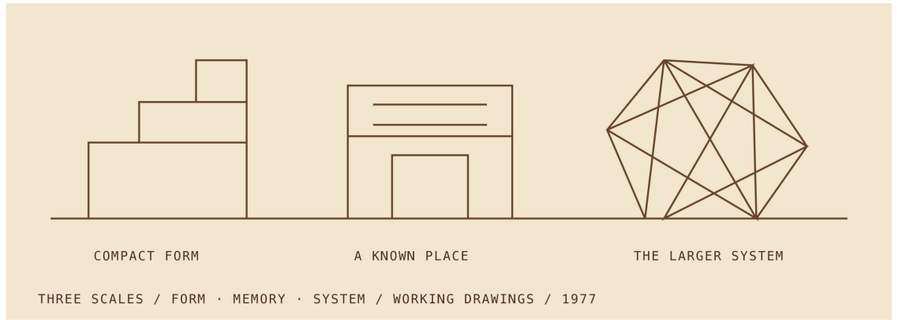
The service drawing must travel with the beautiful perspective: air, heat, maintenance, an ordinary route home. A viewing room is useful if it changes the visitor's attention after the visit is over.

CONVERSATIONS / CONVERSAZIONI / EN

THREE SEATS AT THE TABLE

Paolo Soleri, Aldo Rossi, R. Buckminster Fuller. Three ways of unfolding an island.

The editorial round table



FORMA, MEMORIA, SISTEMA / TRES ESCALAS DE ATENCIÓN

Three names in the architecture notebook: Paolo Soleri, Aldo Rossi and R. Buckminster Fuller. Beside them, three drawings of the same island. One gathers buildings into a compact figure. One studies a square and the streets which remember it. One follows the lines out past the edge of the paper. We have arranged these working portraits around a common table.

SOLERI / THE COMPACT CITY. A town which grows upwards and inwards might release the land around it. The small distances inside the drawing are as important as its great outline: a child reaching a workshop, an older neighbour finding the common room, a garden close enough to be part of an ordinary day. The editors add a second sheet for food, water and the pleasures of being alone. The daily arrangements make the ambitious figure inhabitable.

ROSSI / THE TOWN THAT REMEMBERS. A harbour stair, a shaded threshold, the outline of a square: a town contains things which continue while its inhabitants change. What would an entirely new settlement remember? The question sends the workshop back to its entrances and gathering places. A room below the sea might still need a recognisable address. The next drawing begins at the scale of a person arriving on foot.

FULLER / THE LARGER SYSTEM. The house is an arrangement of materials and energy whose story begins long before anyone turns a key. Its lines lead towards ships, mines, power stations and replacement parts. A light structure may have a surprisingly large shadow. The editors unfold a sheet which is inconveniently larger than the table. There is pleasure in finding that a better account of the whole can suggest a more generous use of each part.

CINÉMA / WORLDS IN THE MAKING / EN

A future with fingerprints

The joke has a serious ancestry. A court fool can tell a king what an adviser cannot; carnival borrows the crown and discovers how readily it fits a donkey. Here the elevated hope is that a better arrangement will make better lives. Gilliam keeps introducing the person who enjoys being in charge of the arrangement. His own drawing is no exception. The official in its doorway bears a suspicious resemblance to its author.

At the housing table, the communal kitchen becomes a scene. There must be somewhere to put a hot pan while another person searches for the cupboard. The perfect terrace acquires a chair which belongs to somebody rather than to the composition. Gilliam tips the perspective a little; a room which seemed quite settled becomes uncertain. "You will still need somewhere to sulk," he observes. The private room survives the afternoon's deliberations.

For all the mischief, he stays with the drawings. He wants to know how the glider lands, how the underwater window is cleaned, what the village sounds like after supper. These are questions from someone who would like to enter the picture. As the sheets are packed, a few of their inhabitants have ceased to stand politely at the edge. One is busy. Another has moved a chair. The future has acquired somebody capable of laughing at it from inside.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

FROM THE FILM DESK / 1977. Three views of the same proposal: the room before its inhabitants arrive; the room in use; the room being repaired. Keep all three in the drawing set.

CUADERNO DEL CINE / ONE EVENING



PROYECCIÓN DE LA TARDE / TENERIFE, 1977

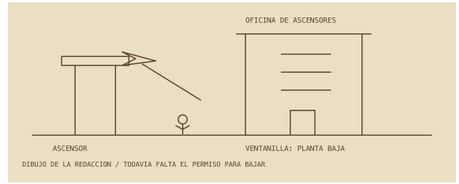
After the last reel

For one evening, Sheldon Renan and Andy Warhol are among those passing through. Renan finds a projector; someone from the harbour brings a film. Warhol watches a fisherman repairing a net, his hands repeatedly disappearing beyond the frame. Afterwards he asks Renan to watch that part with him again. The projector waits while the two friends compare what each has noticed. Renan, who has been discussing how to bring films to people, begins asking what films the people might bring. Neither has much to say at breakfast. Both ask whether a copy can be made.

CORRESPONDENCIA / CARTAS A LA MESA

OBJECTIONS RECEIVED BEFORE SUPPER

Three contributions which did not fit the concluding statement.



DIBUJO DE LA REDACCIÓN / LA OFICINA TAMBIÉN NECESITA UNA ESCALERA

EL CAMINO / A PATH IS ALREADY A DECISION
A note from a resident near Santa Cruz: Ustedes dibujan una carretera para acercarnos. Antes de hacerlo, vengan por el camino. No está vacío. Hay puertas, una acequia y un sitio donde esperamos a quien sube despacio.

You draw a road to bring us closer. Before doing so, come by the path. It is not empty. There are doors, a water channel and a place where we wait for somebody who climbs slowly. The drawing office asks to retain the note with the route plan.

REPLY FROM THE TRANSPORT TABLE
The path will be walked before the line is redrawn. There is still a question of carrying a person who cannot climb it. The editors print both points. A beloved difficulty is not necessarily a difficulty everyone can bear.

LIBERTÀ / WHO MAY BE ALONE?
An Italian delegate objects to the phrase "a new communal life" if it requires every meal to become a meeting. Una porta che si chiude non è sempre un rifiuto. A door that closes is not always a refusal. The housing table restores a small room to the plan.

AU SUJET DU SILENCE
A French note asks whether the underwater room needs a lecture at all hours. Si le poisson ne vient pas, pouvons-nous attendre? If the fish does not come, may we wait? The television workshop replies that the waiting may be the scene.

The cartoon above arrives without an explanation. The transport secretary recognises the second tower immediately and asks whether its office could be combined with the receiving station. By the end of lunch, somebody has pencilled in a third building for the committee considering the combination.

EDITORIAL PRACTICE
The letters are not a plebiscite. Their writers have seen different parts of the island and will bear different parts of the proposals. We print them together because a disagreement can be more useful than a smooth paragraph agreed upon by people who are leaving tomorrow.

CARTAS / LETTERS. Se admiten objeciones. Indiquen qué cambiarían en el dibujo. Objections welcome; please say what you would change.

CINÉMA / THE LIVING SEA / EN

A WINDOW LONG ENOUGH TO CARE

Jacques-Yves Cousteau leaves Tenerife with the beginnings of a new odyssey.

Lucien Morel · Television notebook



SALA DE OBSERVACIÓN / ATELIER DU REGARD

At the ocean workshop, the most consequential drawing was not the submarine tram. It was a room with somewhere to sit. Beyond its curved window lay a stretch of seabed; inside, a bench, a table and the possibility of remaining. Cousteau stayed beside this drawing after the discussion had moved on. By the end of the conference it had become the first scene in a new television proposal.

He had arrived with a lifetime of looking beneath the surface already behind him. His underwater-house experiments had made the seabed a place where people could work and remain. His films had brought that world into homes far from any coast. What Tenerife offered was a different company around the window: architects discussing the shape of attention, painters interested in the changing light, musicians asking what could be heard when the room fell quiet.

The proposed habitat would receive small groups of artists, naturalists and neighbours. Its viewing platforms were places to return to, at different hours, until the apparently empty patch of rock became a place of recognisable lives. A fish which crossed the window each morning could become more than an example of its species. The observer might begin to notice its absences. The architecture had provided enough time for a relation to form.

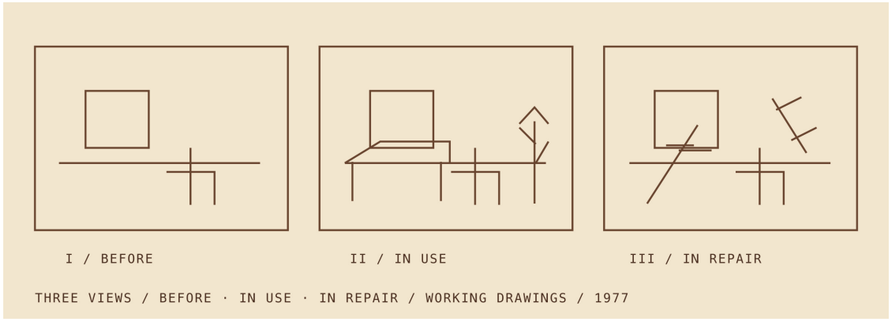
This was the impulse Cousteau carried into the new series, The Cousteau Odyssey. The camera would still travel with Calypso, follow a difficult dive and enter the mysteries of a wreck. But the conference had given the journey another centre: the patient encounter, and the passage from admiration to affection. A television set could become a temporary room beneath the water, with a whole family gathered at its window.

CINÉMA / WORLDS IN THE MAKING / EN

A FUTURE WITH FINGERPRINTS

Terry Gilliam, after Jabberwocky, among the drawings of tomorrow.

Lucien Morel · Film desk



LA MISMA HABITACIÓN / ANTES, EN USO, EN REPARACIÓN

The future has been drawn very carefully. The floor is clean, the chairs agree with one another, and the person beside the window appears to have no possessions which the architect has not approved. Terry Gilliam studies the perspective. “Where do they keep the things they are ashamed of?” A cupboard is added. It is the first amendment of the morning.

He comes to Tenerife in the year of Jabberwocky, his first feature as sole director after sharing Monty Python and the Holy Grail with Terry Jones in 1975. He is finding a voice outside the familiar company, with no settled kingdom of his own to defend. Among the grave pronouncements, he acquires something like the fool’s privilege: permission to touch the robes and ask what is underneath.

There is an old company behind this young disturbance. Bosch and Bruegel crowd the world with appetites which no orderly scheme quite contains; the engraved worlds of Dürer and Doré give even the fantastic a formidable material weight. Carroll makes authority ridiculous by allowing its rules to speak at length. Fellini lets the procession swell until dignity and grotesquerie share a face. In Gilliam’s crowded frames, the grand design must make room for the body, and the body has brought its lunch.

At the transport table, a tower raises the little aircraft to its departure height. Gilliam admires the principle, then draws a second tower beside it. “The office which gives you permission to use the first one.” The engineer laughs and asks whether the office needs a lift. Within minutes the margin contains a much larger building than the original station. Somebody writes ADMINISTRATION across it in very small letters.

ECONOMY / ECONOMIA / EN

Credit for things that last

There are difficult questions. How does a resident leave? Who inherits a right of use? What prevents a committee from becoming a landlord with longer meetings? The workshop prints these questions beside the prospectus, rather than leaving them for the small type.

A draft subscription certificate appears on the table after lunch. Its first promise is a right to take part in decisions. Its second is a duty to keep the place in good repair. A delegate proposes that the annual meeting begin with a tour of everything which has worn out. This attracts an unexpected amount of support from the architects.

Creative finance is useful when it makes durable work possible. If it merely makes the liabilities harder to find, we should return it to the drawing office. The island is not improved by moving a debt from the beach to the horizon.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

The draft certificate is reproduced among the loose leaves. No subscriptions are to be accepted before the terms of membership, maintenance and withdrawal have been agreed.

COOPERATIVA DEL PORVENIR

Before issuing the certificate

The subscription is not the agreement. Rights of use, hours of care and a dignified way to leave must be settled while everyone can still alter the terms. Print the repair account as prominently as the promise.

CINÉMA / THE LIVING SEA / EN

A window long enough to care

On peut montrer la mer comme une succession de merveilles. On peut aussi laisser au spectateur le temps de rencontrer une vie. Une fenêtre, un peu de silence, le retour d'un même poisson: l'étonnement devient attention, puis attachement. Le film commence lorsque nous cessons de demander à la mer de nous distraire.

In the viewing-room study, art was part of learning to stay. A drawing took longer than a glance. A composer listening through a hydrophone might hear a pattern which the visitor had dismissed as background. The shared work could travel back to the surface as a film, a score, a page of marks. The few people who descended would make something for the many who could not. Compassion might pass through those forms without becoming an instruction.

The Cousteau Society, founded in 1973, gives this new resolve a life beyond the screen. The work of witnessing pollution, making it visible and pressing for its reduction belongs beside the work of making a film. The short films of Oasis in Space place the sea within a larger living world. Here in Tenerife, these strands have found a common table. The habitat is an observatory, a studio and a small school of concern; the broadcasts carry its windows into other rooms.

The hospital ship Britannic and other submerged histories will draw viewers towards the new odyssey. Around those histories, the sea continues its own affairs. A wreck is also a place where creatures shelter, feed and begin again. The workshop's departing thought is that a film can hold both kinds of attention: the grief and curiosity of human memory, and the independent lives which have made a home beside it. The sea need not become useful to us before it deserves our care.

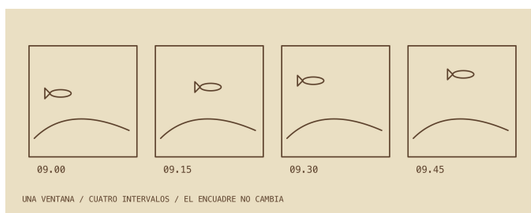
DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

TELEVISION NOTICE / 22 NOVEMBER 1977. The Cousteau Odyssey begins on KCET. From the workshop notebook: let a scene last long enough for its inhabitants to stop being scenery.

ATELIER DU REGARD

The looking room

Allow an interval without commentary. A child may notice the movement at the edge of the window before the lecturer notices it. The room should permit that discovery to become the afternoon's subject.



EL MISMO ENCUADRE / CUATRO INTERVALOS / ESTUDIO DE ATENCIÓN

CUADERNO DE COSTA / FROM THE WATER / EN

THE AFTERNOON WITHOUT A SHORE

Montaña Amarilla. Notes on becoming, for a while, part of the water.

From a visitor's notebook



MONTAÑA AMARILLA / CUADERNO DE COSTA

At Playa de Montaña Amarilla the light was in pieces on the waves. We swam out over the submerged volcanic ridge, looking down through the glitter. Every so often I folded at the waist and went beneath it. Twenty or thirty feet below, barracuda were lined up near the bottom, holding their places in the water. From above there had been only the flashing surface. Down here there were lives going on.

I stayed out with my friends for the whole afternoon. We never went back to shore. We floated, swam, dived, came up for breath and went down again. After a while the beach ceased to be the place to which the afternoon belonged. We were basically fishes with flippers and goggles. The strange part was how ordinary this began to feel.

Another time we slipped beneath the suspended cages of a fish farm, enjoying the small naughtiness of going a little beyond where we were meant to be. Large, lazy turtles moved through the water, and sea rays passed with that slow movement which scarcely seems to require an effort. A dolphin came over to us. It seemed to have arrived for the purpose of meeting us. We had gone there to look down into the water and found ourselves being looked at in return. For a little while there was no better account of the encounter than this: an animal had come to see who was there.

There were small whales, too, on other swims, and blackwater dives in the dark, among what seemed like zillions of tiny, strange creatures. Some seemed barely more than a translucent edge or a minute arrangement of moving parts. I did not have their names. They had the complete strangeness of something imagined, and yet there they were, quite occupied with being alive.

ECONOMY / ECONOMIA / EN

CREDIT FOR THINGS THAT LAST

A prospectus for patient money and impatient people.

Carlo Bellini · Economics correspondent

COOPERATIVA DEL PORVENIR

A share in the long view.

CONSTRUCTION / MAINTENANCE / ACCESS

PROPOSED SUBSCRIPTION / 1977

HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

A house lasts longer than an election, a water main longer than a sales brochure. Yet both must negotiate with money that would prefer to return by Friday. The finance workshop begins with this mismatch and attempts a modest correction: match the term of the obligation to the useful life of the thing.

The proposed island development trust would hold selected land and shared infrastructure. Residents would hold rights of use and participation under published rules. Membership would not be a promise that land values must always rise. A place could become better without becoming less affordable to the people who made it so.

The prospectus separates three funds. The first pays for construction. The second pays for maintenance from the first day, however new the paint looks. The third supports access for households whose work is essential but whose income is irregular. None of these funds can be replenished indefinitely by drawing a more attractive cover.

Il credito è un accordo sul tempo. Se finanziamo una piazza, dobbiamo sapere chi può usarla, chi la cura e chi può cambiare le regole. Il rendimento non può essere l'unica frase del contratto.

COOPERATIVA / NOTE TO THE TREASURER

The repair comes first

Before distributing a surplus, set aside the cost of the next repair. The workshop proposes that the reserve be printed in the annual account beside the dividend. A roof should not have to wait for a profitable year.

ATLAS DEL PORVENIR / ANOTACIONES

EACH ISLAND HAS A NAME.

La Palma
A research exchange and a proposed passenger connection to Tenerife. The open Atlantic becomes a landscape to learn together.

El Hierro
The workshop proposes small-scale energy and water accounting before any large new infrastructure. A small experiment can be an ambitious beginning.

La Gomera
A shared-vessel study asks whether better connections can reduce the pressure to build new roads. Quiet and access are considered together.

Tenerife
The host island: terraced settlements on a disturbed coastal site, a small habitat, and an energy cooperative. Teide is the geographic anchor.

Gran Canaria
A workshop on repair, marine transport and shared fabrication. A proposed connection to Tenerife includes the workshops and spare parts that make a route a service.

Fuerteventura
The wind-and-shade notebook begins with building orientation and water demand. The first design material is the afternoon shade.

Lanzarote
A conservation session considers compact living alongside volcanic terrain. The proposed intervention is a limit on development before it is a new building.

CUADERNO DE COSTA / FROM THE WATER / EN

The afternoon without a shore

The coast above the water could feel just as improbable. Houses stood one above another against the cliffs, finding a ledge, making a stair, borrowing a little shelter from the rock. From the sea, their white walls belonged to the dark face of the island in a way no flat plan could show. A person carrying something down to a boat had to negotiate the actual mountain, step by step.

Elsewhere the island changed its appearance so completely that it seemed we had travelled much farther than we had. Yellow stone, black rock, bare slopes, green folds of land; a mountain appearing above a layer of cloud. The differences were close enough to hold in a day, but they did not become less vivid through being close. The island kept teaching the eye to begin again.

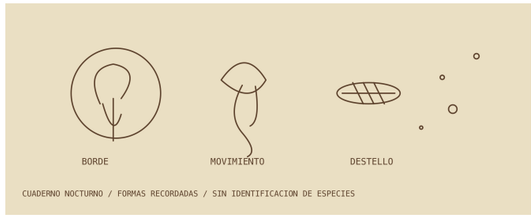
Then there were the calima days. Dust came across from Africa and altered the light. The horizon lost its edge; distances which had seemed certain became difficult to read. Fine powder settled where we had expected clean air. The island was not as separate as its outline on the map. A continent we could not see had entered the room.

When I think of the long afternoon at Montaña Amarilla, I remember the small return to breathing after each dive, and the barracuda still below us when we went back down. They had not come to provide an experience. We had spent a few hours inside the place where they lived. Even after we took off our flippers, the sensation of belonging to the water stayed with us. Walking on land felt, for a little while, like the unusual thing.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

CUADERNO DE COSTA. Above and below the same water: the glittering surface, the submerged ridge, the lives which continue when the swimmer comes ashore.

CUADERNO / BLACKWATER



CUADERNO DE BLACKWATER / FORMAS RECORDADAS, NO IDENTIFICACIONES

Forms in the dark

Tiny edges and threads of movement appear in the dark. These marks record the surprise of looking, not a catalogue of species. The swimmer comes up for breath; the lives below continue.

VIDA COMPARTIDA / WORKING TOGETHER

A FUTURE OF HIS OWN

Oleaje, Shanee's Andalusian stallion, brought from Seville. Notes on learning to ask.

From an island notebook



EL CABALLO / TENERIFE

His name was Oleaje: the swell, a continuous succession of waves. He belonged to Shanee. He had come from Seville, a beautiful Andalusian stallion, formally schooled in the Spanish discipline. He knew how to answer a person's request with an exact movement. Against Teide, his pale body was always startling: this gentle, strong animal in front of a mountain which belonged to another measure of time.

The work then became a kind of untraining, followed by learning together again. We wanted his willingness to matter. An invitation had to leave room for an answer we had not already chosen. If he paused, or turned away, something in our plan could change. His future was to become more his own, rather than a sequence of beautifully executed decisions made for him.

Once he threw me. I became tangled in a lead rope and he dragged me around the arena. The animal I knew as gentle was also immensely strong. Afterwards, that contrast remained with me. Affection did not make him small, and gentleness did not make his strength disappear. There was another body here, with its own alarm, movement and intention.

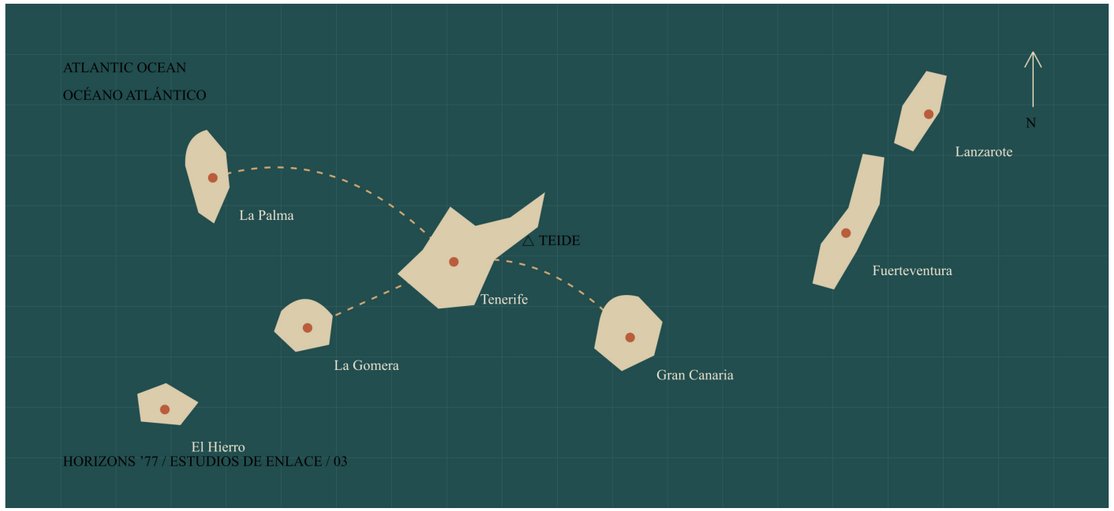
To work with him was to attend to that other life. The lesson did not end when a movement had been performed correctly. It continued in whether he chose to remain with us, whether an encounter left more room for trust, whether we could let an unfinished exercise be enough for the day. We were learning to recognise a decision which was not ours.

I kept returning to the sight of him against the mountain. A pale animal, alert and particular, with Teide behind him. So much of the conference concerned the future we might build for others. Here was a smaller, daily question: could we share a future without deciding every part of it?

TRANSPORT WORKSHOP / ROUTE STUDY 03

SEVEN ISLANDS. MANY FUTURES.

The space between places is a place too.



ISLAS CANARIAS / SCHEMATIC GEOGRAPHY / PROPOSED LINKS

La Palma, La Gomera, Tenerife, Gran Canaria. Every line is a question. Notes from each island follow on page 34.

MOVEMENT / MOBILITÉ / EN

The sky, by lift

Les stations ne vendent pas le vent; elles fournissent de la hauteur. Un premier ascenseur, un vol plané, puis un second ascenseur si le voyage continue. Le ciel devient un réseau de départs, de descentes et de nouvelles possibilités. La correspondance se prend au rez-de-chaussée.

The energy has not disappeared. Raising an aircraft takes work, and the air gradually receives the energy of its descent. The proposed economy lies in efficient fixed lifting equipment, lighter craft and less machinery carried through every mile of the journey. The workshop asks for an account of the whole trip, including the lifts and the return of aircraft. A tower must earn its place in that account as well as in the skyline.

Wind and terrain give the network its actual shape. A station must be within a safe glide of the next receiving point, with room for an alternative landing; headwinds shorten the reach. A mountainside is no substitute for a clear approach. The island plan therefore begins with land routes and trials between neighbouring stations. Lines towards La Gomera, La Palma and Gran Canaria await a much more demanding study of weather, distance and the sea below.

The drawings have an unexpected quietness. A visitor arrives at a tower with a small machine, rises above the roofs and spends the afternoon's height on the journey home. At a distant station there may be a brief wait for the next lift. The waiting room has been given a generous window. For once, the view and the means of transport have been designed together.

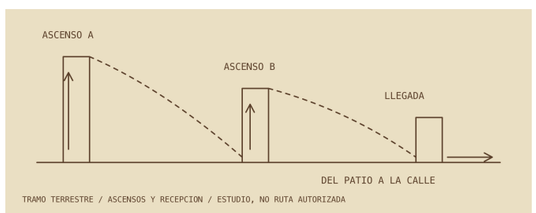
DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Flight study 05. The sawtooth line records powered ascent at each tower followed by an unpowered glide. It is a principle diagram, not a surveyed route or a performance claim. Compare total lifting energy, craft mass and weather margins before choosing station spacing.

TRANSPORT DESK / LANDING NOTE

A journey is a section

Mark the departure height, the safe arrival and the next ascent. A route across the island may be a sequence of descents, but the traveller must still find a path from the landing place to a friend's door.



TRAMO TERRESTRE / PATIOS DE RECEPCIÓN Y SALIDA A PIE

CONSERVATION / LA VIDA EN COMÚN / EN

A PLACE FOR OTHER LIVES

Jane Goodall, a new institute, and the forest beyond the conference table.

Elena Suárez · From the common table

GOMBE / OBSERVATION · CONTINUITY · CARE

1960 — 1977

The forest continues beyond the drawing.

HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

There is a moment in the housing discussion when Jane Goodall draws beyond the edge of the plan. The architect has marked a house, a garden and a place for neighbours to meet. Her pencil follows a line out of the garden and into the trees. The drawing has acquired inhabitants who will never be issued a delegate's pass.

Goodall brings to Tenerife the long attention of Gombe, where her study of wild chimpanzees began in 1960. It is an attention to particular lives, continued across years: relationships, habits, departures and returns. At the ocean workshop, she recognises something familiar in the proposal to remain beside a window until an animal ceases to be an anonymous part of the view. The window looks into the sea; the obligation of looking continues far beyond it.

In the conversations which follow, the idea of an institute becomes a practical form for that obligation. A field notebook can preserve an observation. An organisation might preserve the conditions in which the next observation can be made: a research station, a living forest, the time of the people doing the work. The Jane Goodall Institute, founded in the United States this year, carries the discussions away from Tenerife with a larger horizon than any single expedition.

The conference helps make its purpose tangible. Research needs continuity, and continuity needs friends who can act at a distance. A teacher, a donor, a person making a film and a neighbour living beside the forest can each sustain a different part of the work. The problem is how to connect them without allowing the distant committee to become more important than the place it exists to serve.

CONSERVATION / LA VIDA EN COMÚN / EN

A place for other lives

La vida de un animal no empieza cuando lo vemos ni termina cuando apartamos la mirada. El bosque continúa detrás de la fotografía. También continúan las vidas de quienes habitan cerca de él. Una institución que quiera cuidar ese lugar tendrá que aprender a escuchar en más de una dirección.

At the common table, this becomes a proposal for conservation with people rather than around them. The knowledge and decisions of neighbouring communities must help shape the work. The forest cannot be protected for long by treating its human neighbours as an inconvenience; nor can its other inhabitants be reduced to a resource which earns its place by paying for itself. Both errors begin by leaving somebody out of the drawing.

Goodall's account of chimpanzee life also prevents an easy sentimental conclusion. Kinship does not depend on finding our neighbours in the forest endlessly gentle, or conveniently like ourselves. A creature has a life of its own, including purposes we may find difficult to understand. Care has to survive that discovery. The institute's task is large enough to hold patient research, education and protection together, without requiring a comforting picture at every turn.

By the final afternoon, the architect has redrawn the boundary of the original plan. It now shows where the garden ends, where a path continues and where the trees are to remain. There is no ceremonial unveiling. A little more of the world has been allowed to stay in the picture. It is the kind of change an institute might spend a lifetime learning to make.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

FROM THE COMMON TABLE / 1977. Keep the fieldwork continuous. Let the people closest to a place help decide its care. Make room in the account for lives which cannot attend the meeting.

FROM THE TEACHING TABLE

The part beyond the fence

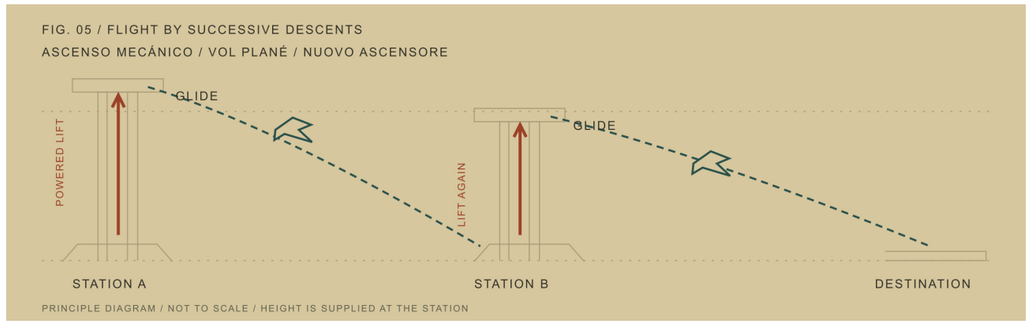
Asha Mehta asks: Must the children come back with the names of everything they have seen? Reply from the teaching table: Let them come back with something they have noticed. The list of species can wait for the next walk.

MOVEMENT / MOBILITÉ / EN

THE SKY, BY LIFT

Skyscraper stations, personal gliders, and the useful art of coming down.

Inés Duarte · Transport workshop



ASCENSOS SUCESIVOS / DIAGRAMA DEL PRINCIPIO

The journey begins in a lift. A small personal aircraft rolls into a cradle at the foot of a slender skyscraper station; its occupant stays beside it as the doors close. Above the town, a departure gallery opens to the wind. The wings unfold, the craft is released, and the passenger sets off towards a destination lower in the sky. Most of the journey is a descent.

This is the transport workshop's proposal for conserving energy in personal flight. Instead of asking each aircraft to carry the machinery and fuel for its own climb, a fixed electrical installation raises craft and passenger together. Height becomes a service supplied by the station. The light aircraft then spends that height in a long, controlled glide. What is heavy stays in the tower; what travels can be lighter.

The station is drawn as a skyscraper with a very particular top floor. Beneath the departure gallery are the lifting machinery, inspection rooms and a weather office. At ground level, a receiving court allows the wings to fold before the next ascent. A person might own the aircraft while using the lifting station in common, much as a private boat uses a public harbour.

A nearby journey needs one ascent and one glide. A farther journey is a chain of descents. The traveller glides to the receiving court of a second tower, is lifted again, and leaves at a fresh altitude. Across a large district there might be two intermediate ascents before the final landing. On the route drawing, distance is bought in successive parcels of height.

SECRETARÍA / CUENTA PROVISIONAL

THE FUTURE IS NOT PAID FOR YET

A report from the table with the envelopes. The sum remains open.

CONCEPTO	PAGADO	PENDIENTE
PAPEL / COPIAS	✓	
GUAGUA / REGRESO		———
COCINA / HORAS		———
CERRAR NO ES SALDAR		

CUENTA DE SECRETARIA / NO SE COMPENSAN HORAS CON AGRADECIMIENTOS

CUENTA DE CIERRE / PAGADO Y PENDIENTE SON COLUMNAS DISTINTAS

The conference has produced plans for an energy cooperative, a marine observatory and an entirely new relation to property. At the smaller table by the door, a woman is trying to establish who ordered the extra paper. The carbon copy is faint. Two signatures appear to belong to the same person.

PENDIENTE / STILL TO SETTLE

Additional duplicating paper; the return journey for the hired guagua; the kitchen's extra hours; an extension to the hire of the projector. The envelopes are labelled in Spanish. The proposals inside them have been discussed in five languages.

A delegate offers to put the kitchen's work in the acknowledgements. The secretary puts it in the account as well. This amendment is accepted without a vote. It is the afternoon's most definite contribution to the theory of shared labour.

AGUA / WATER

At the energy table, the island's existing water galleries return to the discussion. Water already travels through an architecture of shafts, channels, shares and maintenance. A new cooperative cannot begin by pretending that this arrangement is an empty space on its map.

The visitors have drawn an arrow from the mountain to the settlement. A local respondent asks them to name the channel, the right of passage and the person who will repair the leak. The arrow is given a separate sheet. It has become more expensive, and much more interesting.

NO HAY CAMBIO / SMALL CHANGE

The cash box contains several peseta notes and too little change. Someone proposes accepting a promise against a future subscription. The proposal is admired and declined. The guagua must be paid for before departure.

Nothing in this account disproves the larger prospectus. It gives it a beginning. If the conference can leave without making its most generous ideas into somebody else's unpaid evening, it will have performed one useful experiment.

The last envelope is left open for the missing receipt. Above it, the secretary writes provisional. The word is not an embarrassment. It is an instruction to the next person who reads the account.

AVISO / PLEASE NOTE. Un agradecimiento no sustituye un jornal. An acknowledgement does not settle a wage.

KENYA / THE WORK OF BEGINNING / EN

THE FUTURE BEGINS IN A NURSERY

Wangari Maathai and a new movement taking root in Kenya, 1977.

Elena Suárez · From the common table

KENYA / SEED · SOIL · WATER · TENDING



Leave room to grow.

HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

On the table there is a drawing of an island fifty years from now. The houses climb the hillside; a train has found a route between them. Wangari Maathai asks where the water comes from. A finger follows the blue line back across the paper until it stops at the edge. There is another drawing to be made.

In Kenya this year, the Green Belt Movement has begun under the National Council of Women of Kenya. The beginning is close to the ground. Rural women have described streams drying up, food becoming less certain, and longer journeys to gather wood for cooking and fencing. These are accounts of a landscape changing, given by people whose days must accommodate each change. A walk which becomes longer does not appear on an architect's elevation.

Maathai brings the conference back to those journeys. A hillside can be handsome in a perspective and still send somebody farther for water. A settlement can save fuel on the engineer's sheet while consuming more of a woman's afternoon. Before the common ledger is balanced, the people who carry things must be allowed to enter their figures.

Planting trees offers a beginning which people can hold in their hands. But the nursery is already a demanding little institution. Seeds must be found, water carried, young plants tended and a place agreed where they can grow. Someone must return when the visitors have gone. A tree-planting ceremony occupies an afternoon; a living tree asks for a succession of ordinary days.

KENYA / THE WORK OF BEGINNING / EN

The future begins in a nursery

This changes the discussion of scale. Several delegates have been waiting for a proposal large enough to justify the word future. A nursery is small, yet its work can pass from one group to another without every decision travelling back to the same desk. Knowledge moves with the people who practise it. Each new planting must still answer to its own soil, rainfall and neighbours. Repetition need not mean making every place alike.

The island offers a sharp version of the question. On the dry slope, the visitors begin to distinguish an empty-looking piece of ground from ground whose life they have not learned to see. They discuss shelter, water and what can grow here without asking the place to become somewhere else. Nobody proposes planting a forest across every bare volcanic surface. The first task is attention; the next is to find out who already knows.

At the energy workshop, the account acquires another column: the distance walked for fuel. At the housing table, the ground beyond the last wall is drawn with greater care. Maathai, meanwhile, takes away a sheet on the cooperative's arrangements for shared tools and continuing maintenance. The meeting has given her another way to describe work already beginning in Kenya: an undertaking which can spread while remaining in the hands of those who keep it alive.

There is no finished panorama to display at the end of this session. A small schedule passes around the table: seed, soil, water, tending, room to grow. Beside each item there is space for a name. The year 2027 remains fifty years away. Someone will have to water the seedlings tomorrow.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

VIVERO / NURSERY. Begin with the people who know where the water used to run. Record the work of tending as carefully as the day of planting. Leave room for the life which grows beyond the plan.

FATOU DIOP / NOTES FROM THE TABLE

A nursery keeps a calendar

Fatou Diop: Who carries water when the school closes? The first schedule leaves the holidays blank. A second hand writes names across the empty weeks. The nursery now has fewer trees on its first planting day, and a better chance of having them next year.

ENERGY / ÉNERGIE / EN

The sun has no accounts department

Die Sonne liefert keine fertige Gesellschaft. Zwischen dem Kollektor auf dem Dach und dem warmen Wasser in der Küche liegen Rohre, Speicher und die Arbeit vieler Hände. Eine gemeinsame Energieversorgung könnte mehr sein als eine technische Anlage: eine tägliche Übung darin, voneinander abhängig zu sein, ohne einander die Freiheit zu nehmen.

The common ledger records heat, electricity, water and work separately. It does not allow an impressive electrical total to conceal waste in the hot-water circuit. Nor does it count unpaid care as a limitless source of renewable labour. The person who cleans a collector should appear in the accounts beside the collector.

The proposed energy cooperative sells a service rather than a promise of endless consumption. Its members have a claim on reliable light, refrigeration and essential pumping, together with a vote on future investment. There is disagreement over the workshop's evening opening hours. This is encouraging: at last the discussion concerns something people actually need.

If 2027 brings a less conspicuous energy system, it may be because the architecture has learned to ask for less. The best machine on the hillside could be a shaded room in which nobody needs to turn anything on.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

The energy ledger is to be circulated in four columns: generation, storage, demand and maintenance. The last column must include the work, not simply the parts.

TECHNICAL NOTE / FOUR COLUMNS

An account for the evening

Generation, storage, demand, maintenance. Compare the same day at noon and after sunset. A line for work belongs beside the line for equipment; neither is an unlimited resource.

ENERGY / ÉNERGIE / EN

THE SUN HAS NO ACCOUNTS DEPARTMENT

An island energy ledger, with a column for the night.

Lucien Morel · Technical correspondent

FIG. 04 / THE COMMON LEDGER

01	02	03	04
GENERATION	STORAGE	DEMAND	MAINTENANCE

A column for the night. A place for the person who repairs it.

HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

At noon the proposed energy diagram looks generous. Sunlight arrives on roofs, collectors warm water, and a row of small workshops takes its place beneath a shared electrical line. By midnight the same diagram has become a test of honesty. Which stores are full? Which tasks can wait? Who is responsible when a pump stops?

The energy workshop refuses a single victorious machine. It draws solar heat for water, photovoltaic electricity as an ambitious developing option, wind where appropriate, and storage whose cost and materials must be counted. Conservation has a place before generation: shade is a piece of equipment which is unusually quiet.

Geothermal exploration appears as a question mark beneath the volcanic landscape. A volcano on the horizon does not establish a useful reservoir at a convenient depth. The proposal calls for investigation, ecological scrutiny and a public account of failed wells as well as successful ones. A map of heat is not yet a power station.

L'énergie commune demande une politique de l'entretien. Le soleil peut être gratuit; les conduites, les accumulateurs et le travail ne le sont pas. Il faut décider ensemble ce qui doit fonctionner sans interruption, et ce qui peut attendre le matin.

ENERGY DESK / SECOND CALCULATION

Draw the winter day

Repeat the account for a cloudy day, a quiet wind and a collector being repaired. Which demands may wait? Which must continue? A useful installation should be described on the day when it has least to give.

ARCHITECTURE / ARQUITECTURA / EN

A TOWN THAT LEARNS THE SLOPE

Building together without making the mountain disappear.

Elena Suárez · Architecture workshop



TALLER DE ARQUITECTURA / COCINA Y TERRAZA COMPARTIDAS

The plan begins with a contour. It is tempting to improve this line until it becomes straight, but a straight line on this hillside is an expensive opinion. Our workshop leaves it alone. The buildings gather alongside it, making a sequence of narrow terraces rather than a platform large enough to forget the mountain.

On the lower slopes of Tenerife, the workshop imagines repairing a patch of disturbed ground with a compact settlement. A shaded path threads between dwellings, following the hillside towards a workshop and a small public room. Teide gives the plan its orientation. From the upper terrace a resident could see the mountain before putting on the kettle.

At the heart of each cluster is a kitchen large enough for several households. This does not abolish the smaller kitchen. Some evenings require company; some require an egg and a closed door. Common life succeeds when it enlarges the available choices. It fails when the drawing confuses proximity with agreement.

Un pueblo no se construye solamente con casas. También necesita sombra, tiempo, cuidados y la posibilidad de decir: hoy prefiero estar solo. La plaza debe admitir la fiesta y la silla vacía.

ARCHITECTURE / ARQUITECTURA / EN

A town that learns the slope

Il futuro di una casa comincia anche fuori dalla porta. Un banco dove riparare una sedia, una cucina per una cena numerosa, un terrazzo che non appartiene a nessuno e accoglie tutti: il progetto cresce quando lascia spazio agli incontri che non può prevedere. La forma comune non deve cancellare le differenze; deve offrire loro un luogo.

The terraces carry rooms, workshops and gardens, but the roof is not automatically a garden. Soil, water and structure must be counted. A planted roof that consumes more water than a useful field is a handsome misunderstanding. The section distinguishes the shaded court from the irrigated bed and leaves some surfaces bare.

The afternoon discussion turns from compact form to expansive daily life. A carpenter asks for a shared timber store. A parent draws a path along which a child can reach the garden without crossing a road. The plan begins to grow in the spaces between its buildings. By evening, the allocation of afternoon shade has become a subject worthy of its own coloured pencil.

The workshop's most difficult drawing is consequently a calendar. It assigns the use of tools, the care of shared rooms and the work of maintaining paths. A blank space remains beside the question of who can change the rules. Until this space is filled, the town is only a collection of well-arranged walls.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

From the architecture notebook: draw the shaded path before the parking area. Mark the water supply before colouring the gardens. Leave room for a household to change.

ARCHITECTURE WORKSHOP

The threshold is a room too

OBJECTION: The chair will obstruct the passage. REPLY: So will the neighbour standing there to rest. The next plan makes a recess wide enough for both. The committee has added no room, but the path has acquired one.

DELHI / THE PUBLIC TRUST

THE RIGHT TO REFUSE

Habib Rahman, Delhi, and the public architect's difficult signature.

From the public works desk

There is a blank space at the bottom of every proposal which interests Habib Rahman. It is where somebody must eventually sign. The conference has filled many sheets with possible futures. Who is prepared to withhold a signature when a proposal should not be built?

This year his contract as secretary of the Delhi Urban Art Commission has been terminated. He had opposed official proposals, including putting a Gandhi statue beneath the empty imperial canopy at India Gate and placing public conveniences where they would obstruct the southern entrance to Jama Masjid. A commission intended to scrutinise the city had encountered the inconvenience of scrutiny.

Rahman comes to the island with the experience of building public housing and institutions for an independent India. He has worked with restricted budgets, urgent needs and the conviction that modern architecture should serve ordinary life. He does not regard a large public undertaking as necessarily an enemy. He knows how much depends on who can question it.

At the transport table, his intervention takes the form of a space left on the route plan. Before the line is approved, the people whose ground it crosses must be able to object. The objection must have somewhere to go, and the person hearing it must possess more than a ceremonial chair. A beautiful diagram offers little protection if every decision has already been made.

The finance workshop adds a question to its draft constitution: can the person entrusted with examination refuse the project without losing the means to examine the next one? It is a less attractive sentence than the prospectus title. For the moment, nobody volunteers to remove it.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Who may object? Who must listen? Who can refuse?

FOR THE DRAFT CONSTITUTION

A signature has conditions

Record the objection beside the approval. Name the person responsible for hearing it. Preserve the earlier drawing, so that the next committee can see what was changed and why.

LIFE & FORM / CHRISTOPHER ALEXANDER

IV / A fitness for life

On returning, I opened my notebook at a page which had contained a plan. I wrote a different question beneath it. Could we judge a whole house by the life it helped to sustain? Could a settlement have a fitness, belonging to the people and the landscape together, which was more searching than its price, its area, or the elegance of its drawing?

I began a schedule: places where people may meet without an appointment; places where they may withdraw without being banished; the work of carrying, tending and repairing; the paths between the old and the young; the sun, the wind, the water and the living ground. We might make an account for the whole house, then for the cluster, then for the village. A score would express the fitness of their relations, rather than reward a room for being large.

Such a score would have to be made here, with these people, in this landscape. Give the same house another wind, another household, another way of making a living, and its fitness changes. The fisherman must help decide what counts. So must the person who waits at home, and the child who will inherit the path. There must also be a place in the account for what cannot come to the meeting: the rock, the tide, the creatures whose shore we share.

Perhaps, in the distant year 2027, a computing machine could work with us on this. We could give it a family of possible arrangements and a provisional measure of their fitness. It could move a door, widen a landing, join two terraces, turn a roof towards the sun; score the whole again; retain promising arrangements and vary them further. Patterns might evolve through many generations of trial, each fitted more closely to a particular people and place.

The number would be an instrument of attention. Its terms would remain open to the inhabitants, who could change them when a successful plan proved unkind in use. The machine might search a thousand arrangements while we slept. In the morning someone would still have to walk the path, carry the bucket and discover whether the drawing had understood the life. This is how the account would learn.

I returned to the book I have been working on with a different sense of its necessity. I wanted to finish it now, and to let this village enter its very foundations. The timeless way of building was no longer distant or difficult to find. It had a white wall, a stair descending towards the sea, and a man who had taken the morning to show us where he lived. I thought of it as a village of hearts: not because anyone had drawn them, but because each house seemed to make room for another. I could not go back to drawing as though the houses were mute.

PATTERN NOTEBOOK / A TEST FOR THE TEST

Keep the judgement open

Ask the inhabitants to mark where the proposed measure fails them. A house may score well and still have nowhere for a particular life to unfold. Keep those objections with the drawing. If a machine is ever to assist this work, it must leave room for the answer it was not taught to expect.

LIFE & FORM / CHRISTOPHER ALEXANDER

THE VILLAGE THAT BUILT US

Bocacangrejo. A fisherman, a narrow stair, and a different measure of a house.

Christopher Alexander · Notes after the coastal excursion



BOCACANGREJO / CUADERNO DE LA EXCURSIÓN / 1977

The fisherman came to the conference in the morning, though he had neither a paper nor any newspaper-wrapped fish to deliver. Afterwards he waited by the path until a few of us were ready to follow. He led us down towards the sea. Where to put a foot, where to turn, where to wait: these things he showed us by doing them. He carried nothing that suggested he was about to give a lecture.

Bocacangrejo appeared below us in pieces: a white wall, a flat roof, the mouth of a room cut into the dark rock. The way down was so narrow that we could not continue our conversation side by side. Our guide said very little. We watched his feet and the places where his hand rested on the wall. At one turn he waited until I looked up, then showed me where the path continued. We followed our guide one behind another, turning where the houses required us to turn. A terrace became a passage. A passage arrived at somebody's door. Below the last wall, the sea was moving with considerable patience.

The houses had been made by the people who lived in them, and altered as their lives required. A small room had grown out of a cave. Another room had settled above it. Whitewash crossed the meeting of stone and masonry without announcing which was the original building. It was difficult to decide where one house ended. It was easy to see where someone might sit.

Our guide stopped on a landing to help a woman pass a bucket. This required a brief rearrangement of all of us. I stepped back into the shade of a doorway; somebody inside moved a chair. The interruption was over almost before I had noticed it. Yet it was this small event, rather than the view, which I found myself unable to leave.

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II / What the houses knew

I saw suddenly that the landing was doing work upon us. Its shape had made room for an encounter and required us to answer it. The door, the step and the narrowness of the passage had brought four separate lives into one small action. No instruction had been issued. Nobody had reminded us to be neighbours.

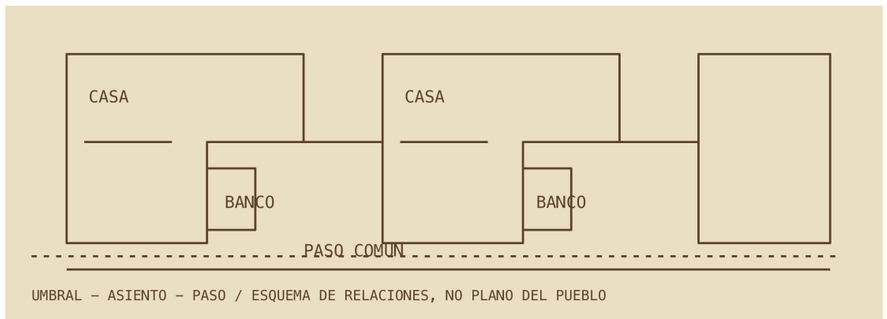
A chill went through me. I remember the rough wall against my hand, and a sound from the water below, and then the extraordinary stillness in which these ordinary things seemed to become completely intelligible. For a moment I could see the village as a single living arrangement. The families lived from the sea, but also beside, above and around one another: a group organism whose smallest exchanges kept it alive.

What we build builds us in turn.

I had thought I understood this. I had written about relations between things, and spent years trying to describe the life which makes a place whole. Here the thought ceased to be something I could stand apart from. The village was making an action possible, and I was already inside the action. There was no position outside it from which I could remain merely its observer.

The houses were a lesson in how to live, written without a lecturer. A child carried something for an older person because the stair brought them together. A repair remained visible long enough for another pair of hands to join it. The sea determined when a boat could leave; the landing determined how its catch came home. Each household had a life, but no household had to invent the whole of life alone.

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UMBRAL, ASIENTO Y PASO / ESQUEMA DE RELACIONES

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III / The necessary effort

We walked on. At a wet patch our guide changed his footing; at a turn he waited for someone coming up. I found myself asking what it meant to be of a place. To need its water, to read its weather, to be taught by its surfaces every morning. His knowledge was in the pauses as much as the steps. We were interpreting, and could easily miss something. To come here was to be here, with your feet and your breath and the attention the path demanded.

In our plans we have become very accomplished at removing demands. We separate the door from the street, the dwelling from the workshop, the private arrival from the common path. We can deliver a person safely to a room without requiring that person to acknowledge another soul. Afterwards we wonder why the room feels lonely. We have made isolation an architectural convenience.

An asphalt line could be driven across this complexity and make a quick, clear drawing. It would also cut across the arrangements by which people found water, carried a catch home and met one another. The path had learned the place in smaller movements. Here there was a useful grain of resistance. You carried the chair, waited at the bend, called to someone above you. A task asked a little more of your body and, in doing so, recruited another person into the day. The effort had a social form. I began to think of a house as something which could exercise our capacity for affection as surely as a stair exercises our legs.

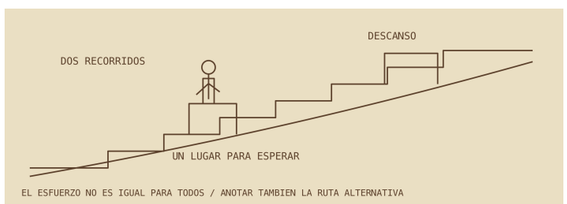
This was the distinction I wanted to bring back to the conference: between effort which exhausts us and effort which joins us. A broken water pipe leaves a family with work to endure. A well-placed common tap can leave two neighbours with a meeting. A path should be repaired so that a person can use it, yet remain a place where people see one another. Care need not disappear when comfort arrives.

The village had privacy, but its edges were inhabited. A door could close. A chair could be drawn just outside it. There were degrees of belonging between the room and the sea. At those edges, people had repeated small chances to become more patient, more useful, more known. A building could make a better person more likely, by giving that person something worth doing for someone else.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

The conquest of Tenerife ended in 1496. It brought enslavement and assimilation, but Indigenous people and customs persisted. The island did not begin with the conquerors' maps.

DEL CUADERNO / 3



EL CAMINO / DESCANSO Y RECORRIDO ALTERNATIVO